EXECUTIVE BRIEFING · OPERATOR LAYER

Module 2 Insider Playbook

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MODULE 2 INSIDER PLAYBOOK — TARGET ARCHITECTURE: The Listening-Map Cheat Codes

Executive briefing. The targeting layer that the lessons build. Read after 2.1–2.4.

THE MARKET-TIER SYSTEM (STOP SORTING STATIONS — SORT MARKETS)

Stations don't exist in a vacuum — they live in **market tiers** with different physics. Target by tier, not by size:

Tier	Type	Radio physics	Your play
T1 — College towns	University + community + online density	Hunger for new music, weekly cycles, chart-able	First campaign here, always
T2 — Mid metros	1–3 commercial stations + college + specialty	Add cycles exist, ratings pressure moderate	Second wave, after college proof
T3 — PPM metros	Nielsen-metered, high format discipline	Conservative, ratings-driven, risk-averse	Only with chart evidence
T4 — College-corridor metros	2+ universities within 60 miles	Multiple college lanes, cheap adds	Cascade bonus market

The classic label move: **college-town campaign → chart → mid-metro add → PPM-metro pitch with the chart.** You can't skip tiers and expect breaks. The heat map should be tier-tagged, not just ring-tagged.

CHEAT CODE 1 — THE SPECIALTY-SHOW HUNT

The highest-acceptance inventory in radio isn't a format — it's a **show**. Specialty shows (late-night, genre, regional, themed, new-music blocks) have hosts who need to fill time and love discovering. Find them through:

- Station "shows" / "programs" pages (almost every station lists specialty shows with host names).
- NACC and RMR charts (charting stations have genre-specific shows — see who's charting adjacent artists).
- Instagram/DM direct to hosts (specialty hosts are contactable; MDs are gate-kept).
- Show descriptions: "local focus," "new music," "undiscovered," "hip-hop showcase," "indie hour" — those are acceptance signals.

Rule: one specialty-show add per week is a faster path to a 10-add year than 200 emails to commercial MDs. Week one of every campaign: hunt 10 specialty hosts in your tier-1 markers.

CHEAT CODE 2 — THE FORMAT-INTELLIGENCE RADAR

A station's website says one thing; its playlist says everything. Before scoring any station:

1. Pull the **last 10–15 songs** (website "recently played," online stream history, or the station's socials).
2. Log tempo, energy, era mix, and genre drift — is it "alt but plays pop?" "country but plays rock crossover?"
3. **Check the specialty shows** — a station might look closed but host a local show that's wide open.
4. Compare against your track. Judge the gap, not the label.

Format scores without playlist reality are fiction. The 12-point check exists to stop you from pitching the station's brand instead of its clock.

CHEAT CODE 3 — WHO ACTUALLY DECIDES (THE CONTACT TRIAGE)

Different stations, different deciders:

- **Commercial:** MD (music director) for adds; PD for rotation upgrades; APD sometimes. Start at MD; escalate politely.
- **College:** music director (often several, per genre) — the **genre MD** is the real target, not the station's general email.
- **Community/specialty hosts:** the **host** decides the show; the MD decides the station. Pitch the host for the show, then use the show as a route into the station.
- **Online:** the founder/owner is usually the decider and the most responsive human in radio.

Insider move: a station's "music director" receives 100+ emails. A station's genre-specific MD receives 12. Find the genre MD. This one change alone can triple your reply rate.

CHEAT CODE 4 — THE 20-STATION ALLOCATION FORMULA

Don't fill your war room 20 random stations. Allocate for outcomes:

- **10 slot-** (specialty + college, high acceptance, proof-producing)
- **6 ladder shops** (stations that can upgrade you from specialty to rotation)
- **3 market-makers** (the one or two commercial stations that matter in each metro)
- **1 wildcard** (a stretch station with an actual human path)

This allocation is why 5 adds in 21 days is achievable: 10 high-acceptance slots aren't a hope, they're a probability.

CHEAT CODE 5 — THE PRE-ROLL FIRE TEST

Before any tour-date campaign: verify the market is actually reachable — drive time, venue capacity, station density, and whether any of your 10 slot stations have a local show that can plug the date. A date with zero station density is a concert, not a campaign. Fire the pre-roll only where the map says yes.

THE ONE SECRET MOST ARTISTS NEVER LEARN

The best 20 stations are not the ones that play your genre — they're the ones that play your neighborhood of the genre. A station that plays 1980s college rock and a station that plays "indie pop but heavier" both say "alt" and both are wrong for you. The playlist radar catches the neighborhood. Format family beats format label, every time.

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